

Kangaroo care A technique, adopted especially with premature babies, where baby and parent have prolonged skin-to-skin contact. This is thought to provide warmth, stimulation, and to encourage the baby to breast-feed.

Lanugo The fine soft hair that grows on the body of the fetus.

Letdown reflex The flow of breast milk into the nipple.

Lie The position in which the baby is lying within the uterus.

Linea nigra A line of dark pigmentation that appears on the skin of the abdomen in some women during pregnancy. It runs down the center of the abdomen over the rectus muscle.

Lochia Postpartum vaginal discharge.

Longitudinal lie The position of the fetus in the uterus in which the spines of the fetus and the mother are parallel.

Low-birth weight baby A baby who weighs below 5 lb (2.5 kg) at birth.

Meconium The first contents of the bowel, present in the fetus before birth and passed during the first few days after birth. The presence of meconium in the amniotic fluid before delivery is usually taken as a sign of fetal distress.

Melasma Dark, uneven patches of skin on the cheeks, forehead, nose, and chin during pregnancy. Exposure to the sun makes it worse. See also *Chloasma*.

Membranes Two layers of protective sacs enclosing the fetus, called the amnion and the chorion.

Meningitis A serious infection of the meninges, layers of tissue covering the brain.

Miscarriage The spontaneous loss of a baby before 20 weeks of pregnancy.

Monozygotic See *Twins*.

Morula A stage in the development of the fertilized egg, 3–4 days after fertilization, when it has grown into around 16 cells.

Multigravida A woman in her second or subsequent pregnancy.

Neonatal A baby less than 28 days old.

Nuchal scan A special ultrasound that can check for risk of Down syndrome.

Nucleus The central part or core of a cell, containing genetic information.

Occipital anterior The position of the baby in the uterus when the back of its head (the crown or occiput) is toward the mother's front (anterior).

Occipital posterior The position of the baby in the uterus when the back of its head (the crown or occiput) is toward the mother's back (posterior).

Opioids (Narcotics) Painkilling drugs that induce drowsiness and stupor.

Ovary One of the two female glands, set at the entrance of the fallopian tubes, which regularly produce eggs until menopause.

Ovulation The release of a ripe egg by the ovary.

Oxytocin Hormone that triggers the uterus to start contracting in the first stage of labor. If you are very overdue, you may be given an extra dose of synthetic oxytocin via an IV.

Palpation Feeling the parts of the fetus through the mother's abdominal wall.

Pelvic floor The springy muscular structure set within the pelvis that supports the bladder and the uterus, and through which the baby descends during labor.

Perinatal The period from the 24th week of gestation to one week following delivery.

Perineum The area of soft tissues surrounding the vagina and between the vagina and the rectum.

Placenta A flat, thick disc-shaped organ that supplies the fetus with oxygen and nutrients.

Placenta previa A placenta situated over, or close to, the entrance to the cervix. This makes a vaginal delivery unlikely.

Postpartum After delivery.

Postpartum hemorrhage (PPH) Excessive bleeding following delivery.

Preeclampsia A condition that features high blood pressure and excess proteins in the urine. May be mild or serious.

Premature A baby born before the 37th week of pregnancy.

Prenatal Before birth.

Presentation The position of the baby according to the part of the fetus that is closest to the cervix before and during labor.

Preterm See *Premature*.

Primigravida A woman in her first pregnancy.

Progesterone A hormone produced in the ovaries and then by the placenta.

Prolactin Hormone that stimulates milk production.

Prostaglandins Natural substances that stimulate the onset of labor contractions. Prostaglandin gel may be used to soften the cervix and induce labor.

Quickening The first sensations of your baby moving. Generally felt for the first time at around 20 weeks.

Rhesus (Rh) factor A distinguishing characteristic of the red blood corpuscles. All human beings have either rhesus positive or rhesus negative blood. If the mother is rhesus negative and the fetus is rhesus positive, rhesus disease (the destruction of the red corpuscles by antibodies) may occur; usually in a subsequent pregnancy unless prevented by an injection of Rh immunoglobulin.